
THE LAST OPEN TAB

Two original gothic-comedy plays

The Door in the Notes · The Price of Perfect

Draft scriptbook • October 4, 2026

Fictional theatre sales appear inside Episode 002. This work does not report real ticket revenue or promise a perfect life.

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SERIES PREMISE

The Last Open Tab — an original serial play for screens and stage

Status: original pilot and working production system, prepared October 4, 2026 (Pacific). The user named Alice: Madness Returns (probable identification of “Alice Revisited”) and Lollipop Chainsaw, then asked for broader gothic research. Exact intended Alice title and live Trends top ten remain unverified; see GOTHIC-RESEARCH.md. Nothing here is presented as a rewrite of an unidentified work or as a current trend claim. The chair-and-presentation frame is fiction; a performer can stage it without physical restraint.

Tonal revision after the user named references

The show is a gothic comic mystery with active stage business: fluttering paper, aggressive projector clicks, deadlines, absurdly cheerful conclusion slides, sudden neon against velvet darkness, and then one earned quiet beat. Mara is curious and wry; Ivo has dry deadline humor; June is exact without being cold. The world and all characters remain original. Avoid recognizable iconography or sequences from the cited works.

One sentence

In a city where unfinished questions become doors, a community projectionist, a skeptical director, and an archivist must close one door each episode while the projector reveals a harder question hiding behind it.

Why it can continue

Each episode has a small answer and a lasting consequence. A question appears in an ordinary place. The team must verify what happened, make a choice and pay a cost. They close the local door, then discover what the answer changes in their relationships or in the city. Episodes can stand alone for a new viewer because the local problem has a clear beginning, middle and end. A season arc accumulates choices; no episode depends on an endless string of unanswered cliffhangers. The series can stop with a satisfying ending at any season gate. “Neverending” describes a repeatable story engine, not a promise of infinite automated publishing.

Rules of the world

1. Questions appear as projected subtitles on objects only when two people honestly disagree about what the object means. The projection never declares a fact.
2. A door opens when the team tests a claim in the real world. It stays open until they record the evidence, the uncertainty and a decision.
3. The projector can reveal memories of actions but cannot read thoughts or predict the future. Its gaps matter.
4. A closed door changes one concrete thing in the city: a route, an agreement, a piece of public art or a relationship. No reset at the end of the episode.
5. The team cannot solve a conflict by humiliating the person who asked the question. The series values curiosity, humor and consent.
6. A trend word is never a magical object by itself. It becomes useful only if it fits a character's present need, the established rules and the episode's emotional question.
7. Every episode ends with a ledger entry: what they thought, what they learned, what changed and what remains open. Previous ledger entries are immutable history; later discoveries may reinterpret them.

Cast and production roles

Mara Vale, projectionist and viewpoint character. Quick with light, slower with certainty. Wants to find her missing mentor. Strength: can show people exactly what she observed. Flaw: rushes to finish a story for others. Her arc is learning to leave room for another person's answer. First-person scenes can use her voice, but other characters keep their own motives.

Ivo Reed, director of the municipal night theatre. Keeps productions on time, guards the building's fragile funding and challenges grand claims. He wants the theatre to survive; his scheduling choices can clash with Mara's investigations. He is neither a villain nor a mouthpiece.

June Arroyo, archivist and dramaturg. Tracks citations, contradictions and physical records. Wants public access to the archive without exposing private lives. She can say “unknown” without surrendering the scene.

The Presenter. An offstage or shadow character who projects dense slides and asks the same question in increasingly specific ways. The Performer in the chair listens, takes notes and eventually chooses to interrupt with a better question. No physical captivity needs to be enacted; the pressure comes from the endless presentation and a ticking show call.

Producer role, in-universe and in production: selects a bounded episode promise, rights-cleared assets, budget and release gate. Director role: controls action, tempo, blocking and reveal. Dramaturg/research role: verifies facts and continuity. Performer role: makes each character's objective visible. Editor role: builds separate vertical and landscape cuts. Sound and access role: captures clean dialogue, captions, transcript and readable visuals. Publisher role: prepares the blog and platform metadata, then verifies actual publication. These roles can be one person wearing separate review hats; their checklists should

remain distinct.

Season one spine — seven question doors

1. The Door in the Notes: Who owns the ending to a story everyone witnessed? Mara learns that the projected record omits a crucial pause.
2. The Price of Perfect: A slide promises Mara a flawless forever if the theatre earns \$10,000 by midnight. The team sells 100 real fictional tickets without surrendering archive rights; money solves a concrete need, while the promise of perfection fails its evidence test.
3. The Map That Moved: A marked route changes overnight. Ivo wants to reopen the theatre by morning; June needs a source for the map. The local route is resolved; a citywide signal emerges.
4. The Borrowed Voice: A recording sounds like the mentor. Mara must prove origin before sharing it. The team's trust bends.
5. The Audience of One: A public performance contains a private message. June protects the person while finding a lawful way to show the truth.
6. The Quiet Rehearsal: Ivo's budget ledger and Mara's story ledger disagree. They both have incomplete evidence. A choice costs them a venue.
7. The Final Projector: The mentor's disappearance gets a grounded answer. The team can preserve or retire the machine; the season ends either way. A new season, if made, follows the changed people and a new question, not an artificially delayed answer.

These are original seeds, not claimed adaptations of the unspecified “following” stories. If the user supplies references, extract only high-level thematic tensions and build fresh events, characters and dialogue. Track each influence in an inspiration register; reject near copies of protected characters, distinctive scene sequences and signature dialogue.

Episode schema

ID; series revision; trend snapshot and date; source-stories/inspiration register; one-line local question; emotional question; character objective/obstacle/choice/cost; established canon used; new canon proposed; opening image; three escalating beats; local resolution; season-arc movement; final image; evidence/rights flags; stage manuscript; ≤180-second Shorts cut when allowed by the current account; separate landscape full episode; blog with text steps or story analysis; publication status; actual audience signals; next episode hook. Unknown values stay unknown.

Story quality gate

Can a newcomer understand the local question in the first ten seconds? Does someone make a consequential choice rather than simply explain a theme? Does the answer change a future episode? Is the ending satisfying even if no one watches the next video? Is the trend word removable without breaking the plot? If removing it improves the story, remove it. Can a performer play the scene with normal props and an affordable location? Are any facts, rights or real-world references unverified? Fix those before publication.

EPISODE 001

THE LAST OPEN TAB

Episode 001: The Door in the Notes

An original short play and screen pilot

Draft: 1.1, October 4, 2026 Pacific. Gothic comic stage revision after the user named game references. Written for four voices, one room, a portable projector or on-screen light effect, a chair, a table, paper notes and a stopped wall clock. Estimated full performance: 6–8 minutes, subject to rehearsal. No physical binding or forced restraint is needed. The “endless presentation” is performed through rhythm, light and the actors' choices.

Cast

- MARA VALE, projectionist, listening from the chair.
- IVO REED, theatre director, guarding the show clock.
- JUNE ARROYO, archivist, guarding the record.
- THE PRESENTER, a live performer or recorded voice. Their motive is to make the room accept a neat ending.

Set: An empty municipal theatre rehearsal room. On the table: a stack of numbered pages, a cup of water, a lamp and a projector remote. Downstage: a chair facing a white wall. The wall shows a too-cheerful acid-neon slide headed “CONCLUSION,” framed by dark theatre velvet. The clock has stopped at 11:59. A strip of tape on the floor marks a place where an unseen door might open.

Before curtain: A low projector fan, then a wildly upbeat three-note “finished!” chime that keeps arriving at the wrong moment. The cue is original and should be composed for this show. Nothing else. In the first beat, the audience sees the last slide of a presentation that seems to have gone on for hours. The performers never need to mime an actual multihour sequence.

Scene 1: The last slide

[The PRESENTATION click sounds. “CONCLUSION” appears again, and a gust from the projector lifts one corner of every page. IVO catches them with his show call sheet. MARA sits in the chair. Her notebook is full. She is free to stand, but the audience sees why she stays: the final slide might answer the question she came for.]

PRESENTER: Conclusion. The mentor left at eleven fifty-nine. No one saw why. Therefore the theatre may close the file.

IVO: Good. We open in twenty minutes. Mara, lights. June, archive the notes. If the slide applauds itself again, I am billing it for a ticket.

MARA: Page twenty-seven is missing.

IVO: It is page twenty-eight.

MARA: Exactly. Our conclusion skipped a stair.

[The PRESENTATION advances. A photograph of the empty theatre appears. Across the door in the photograph, light writes: "WHO FINISHED THIS STORY?"]

IVO: Is that in your cue list?

MARA: No. I only asked about the page.

JUNE: Then someone else asked something too. These letters show up when two people mean different things by one object.

IVO: The object is a page. It means a page. We have sixteen minutes to prove me wrong.

MARA: To you it means an ending. To me it means we have not seen the whole account.

[A narrow line of light falls across the tape on the floor. The wall now looks like a door.]

PRESENTER: Conclusion. There is no door.

JUNE: That's one claim. It is not evidence.

IVO: We have a paying audience downstairs.

MARA: Then let's be on time with the truth.

[She rises from the chair. The projector does not stop.]

Scene 2: The gap

[JUNE lays the numbered pages on the table. IVO checks his watch. MARA points the projector at the wall, then at the paper. A blank rectangle sits between pages twenty-six and twenty-eight. Pages flutter across the tape line; MARA pins them down with the harmless paper remote. The neon "CONCLUSION" keeps glowing above the gap.]

JUNE: We have twenty-six. We have twenty-eight. We do not have twenty-seven. The photograph in the slide is dated, but the original file is not here. I can prove the sequence is incomplete. I cannot prove why.

IVO: An incomplete sequence is not a conspiracy.

JUNE: Agreed.

MARA: Nor is it a conclusion.

PRESENTER: The clock stopped when the mentor left. A stopped clock is a time stamp.

JUNE: A stopped clock is a stopped clock.

[MARA turns the lamp off. On the white wall, the projector replays the mentor entering the theatre. The figure turns toward someone out of frame. The picture freezes. There is no sound.]

MARA: Show the next frame.

[The projector advances to an empty stage.]

MARA: There is a jump.

IVO: Could be a cut.

JUNE: Could be a fault in the machine. Could be an edit. We need the physical notes and the source file.

MARA: June, what is on page twenty-eight?

JUNE: “Everyone agreed that the mentor walked out.”

MARA: Did everyone agree?

IVO: I did. I was here. I saw the coat at the exit.

JUNE: You saw a coat at the exit. Did you see whose shoulders were inside it?

[IVO looks at the photograph.]

IVO: No.

PRESENTER: The audience will not enjoy uncertainty.

IVO: The audience deserves to know where we stand.

Scene 3: The choice

[The clock starts again: tick, tick. IVO picks up the show call sheet. The PREMIERE is now sixteen minutes away. A handwritten note falls from between two sheets.]

IVO: This was in my folder.

JUNE: Read it aloud only if it is meant for the room.

IVO: It is addressed to all three of us. “If the picture skips, do not ask the machine to invent the missing seconds. Ask the people in the room what they did.” Signed, the mentor.

MARA: That's her handwriting.

JUNE: You recognize it. I will compare it with the archive before I call it confirmed. For now, we know the note was in Ivo's folder.

PRESENTER: It changes nothing. The slide is ready. The ending is ready.

IVO: The show is ready. That's different.

[He takes the remote. He can play the polished slide or switch to a live introduction.]

IVO: If I pull the ending, the audience may ask for a refund.

MARA: If you play it, they will believe we know what happened.

JUNE: We can tell them exactly what we know. The room was entered. The clock stopped. A coat was seen. The image skips. We have not verified the missing page or the author of the note.

IVO: Four facts and three holes. That's a difficult opening night.

MARA: It is an honest one.

[IVO turns off the slide. For one beat, the wall is blank. The line of light on the floor becomes a door, then closes. A mark remains: a thin gold line in the wood.]

PRESENTER: You have ruined my conclusion.

MARA: We finished this question. We didn't finish her story.

JUNE: Record it.

[MARA writes in the notebook, speaking as she writes.]

MARA: "We thought the slide proved the mentor left. We learned the record skips. Ivo saw a coat, not a face. We chose to tell the audience the limit. The theatre opens with the question intact."

IVO: "Cost: one clean ending."

JUNE: "Gain: a record someone else can challenge."

[The clock reads 12:00. A house bell rings. IVO opens the real rehearsal-room door. In the hall, someone has placed a coat with no name tag.]

IVO: Mara. Is this the coat I saw?

[MARA reaches for it, stops, and looks back at JUNE.]

MARA: We can check.

[Blackout.]

Canon receipt after episode

Local resolution: The team rejects the claim that the slide proves the mentor left. They agree on a truthful opening for the audience. The question door closes.

Persistent change: A gold line remains on the rehearsal-room floor; the theatre's opening statement changes. Ivo has publicly accepted uncertainty, affecting future budget and trust decisions.

Open thread: Whose coat was at the exit? The mentor's whereabouts remain unresolved. The note's handwriting is a character recognition, not yet archive-verified fact.

Performer note (Mara): I do not play a prisoner. I choose to stay because the last slide may answer a personal question. Standing up is an active choice. My last line is curious, not a cliffhanger gasp.

Director note: The projector's "proof" should look enticingly complete before the missing frame is exposed. Give the blank wall one full breath. Never show an image of a missing page as though it were evidence.

Producer note: One room, one hall edge and four voices are sufficient. Practical light and an original slide deck can replace expensive effects. Clear the rights for the coat photo and all displayed text; preferably film or draw them in-house. No generic trending keyword should be added to a line of dialogue simply for search traffic.

EPISODE 002

THE LAST OPEN TAB

Episode 002: The Price of Perfect

Original gothic-comedy play manuscript — draft 1.0

Place: The municipal night theatre. The gold line left by Episode 001 still crosses the rehearsal-room floor. A real ticket window faces the street. On the wall: a clock and a projector. Four playable voices: MARA, IVO, JUNE and THE PRESENTER. Ensemble ticket buyers may be shown by hands, footsteps and original recorded crowd sound. Approximate rehearsal target: 7–9 minutes. Actual duration must be timed.

The dramatic promise: The Presenter claims that if the theatre makes \$10,000 by midnight, Mara will become perfect, the people she loves will stay together every day, and even their last nights will be painless. The play treats this as a claim made by a character, not a fact about money, death or an afterlife. Mara wants the money because the theatre needs it; she also wants the promised future badly enough to consider believing it.

Scene 1 — The bargain

[A neon slide snaps on: "\$10,000 TODAY = PERFECT FOREVER." A cheery three-note jingle plays. The clock reads 9:06 p.m. Under it, a handwritten notice says the landlord expects a deposit by morning. IVO is counting empty ticket envelopes. JUNE is setting out programs. MARA traces the gold line in the floor.]

PRESENTER: Welcome back. Three hours until midnight. One number between you and a perfect ending.

IVO: If the number pays for this room, it may have a small point.

MARA: What ending?

PRESENTER: Ten thousand dollars in sales today. Then no more awful days. The ones you love stay. When your last night comes, you sleep without pain and wake into a happier story.

[The slide adds an animated halo around MARA's head. She steps out of its circle.]

MARA: You talk like a receipt can promise what no one can.

PRESENTER: Yet you looked at the clock.

MARA: I did.

JUNE: Is this a contract or a slide?

PRESENTER: Does it matter if the ending is beautiful?

JUNE: It matters before anybody signs.

[A new line appears across the gold scar: "WHAT DOES TEN THOUSAND BUY?" The projector-door begins to open.]

Scene 2 — The easy sale

[A single envelope slides under the door. IVO opens it. Inside: a one-page offer to "sponsor" the show for \$10,000. The money would arrive at midnight if the theatre grants the buyer perpetual control of the archive and the right to cut any line from every future play.]

IVO: The amount is right. The terms are an ambush wearing a tie.

PRESENTER: You asked to make the money today. Here is the path.

MARA: It buys the archive. The people whose words are in it never agreed.

JUNE: It also says "payment authorized." Authorized is not captured. The theatre has not been paid a cent.

PRESENTER: You're being difficult about happiness.

JUNE: I am being exact about the price.

IVO: The landlord will not take an authorized adjective.

[He sets the envelope beside the ledger, unsigned. The door stays open.]

MARA: If we keep the room by selling the ending, we will make the same mistake as last night.

Scene 3 — The work

[A queue has formed at the real ticket window. The original play is about to open. IVO has priced a special one-night performance at \$100 per seat; the notice states clearly what a ticket buys. The house has 100 seats. No claim of guaranteed happiness appears on the sign.]

IVO: I set this price weeks ago. I thought we would be lucky to fill twenty seats.

JUNE: What does each ticket include?

IVO: Tonight's performance. A printed program. Access to the archive exhibit we actually have permission to show. Refund terms are on the back.

MARA: Then tell the truth before they pay.

[They open the window. The play does not require filming 100 separate people. Instead, a bell rings on a few real transactions while the house gradually fills. Between moments, the clock moves. A practical montage: a hand receives a ticket; JUNE checks the seat count; IVO changes a sign from 42 to 76 to 99.]

Each number is a stage fiction, not a claim about the real series.]

PRESENTER: Ninety-nine. You need one more. Say I can make them perfect. It fits on the poster.

MARA: The poster says what they get.

PRESENTER: Your happiness is waiting on a sentence.

MARA: My happiness isn't a feature we can sell to strangers.

[The final buyer approaches. It is the MENTOR's old coat, worn by an ordinary audience member whose face we can see. No supernatural reveal.]

BUYER (may be played by PRESENTER with a clear costume and lighting change): Is there one seat left?

IVO: There is. One performance tonight. No promise it'll change your life.

BUYER: Good. I came for a play.

[The buyer pays. JUNE sees the actual fictional point-of-sale confirmation, not a reservation or an unpaid invoice. She and IVO reconcile the 100 paid tickets with the seat count. She writes: "Gross paid ticket sales: $100 \times \$100 = \$10,000$. Refunds, fees, taxes and performance costs still need their own lines."]

Scene 4 — What the number cannot do

[The clock turns 11:59. The Presenter throws a blinding "PERFECT" slide over the full house. IVO cuts the projection. The house is not perfect: a chair squeaks, a program tears, someone coughs. MARA laughs, then almost cries.]

PRESENTER: The number is real. You met my condition. Why won't you wear the halo?

MARA: Because your next claim never came with evidence.

PRESENTER: You wanted every day together. You wanted the last night to be kind.

MARA: I still do. Wanting it does not make you able to sell it.

IVO: We can pay the deposit if the available cash covers it. We still owe a show, refunds if due, and everyone who worked tonight.

JUNE: Ten thousand gross. A real achievement in this story. Not ten thousand profit. Not perfection. We will reconcile the final ledger after the performance.

PRESENTER: So what did the audience buy?

MARA: A night here. A play. A chance to leave with a question they can answer for themselves.

[The gold line across the floor glows. The door opens once more, then shuts on the word "PERFECT." A mark remains beside the old one: a small square the shape of a ticket. The house bell rings.]

IVO: Places.

MARA: I am here.

JUNE: So am I.

[They enter the light together. Blackout.]

Canon receipt, proposed until reviewed

Local question resolved: The theatre earns \$10,000 in gross paid ticket sales inside this fiction without selling permanent control of the archive. The team rejects the Presenter's unsupported promise that a number can make a person perfect or guarantee a painless ending.

Persistent change: The theatre has a full house and an obligation to deliver its show; the gold floor line now carries a ticket-shaped mark. The Presenter has discovered Mara's deepest leverage: a promised future with people she loves. Mara has named that desire without selling it.

Open questions: Who sent the archive-control contract? Who wore the mentor's coat in Episode 001, and why? What will the real net cash be after costs? These are story questions, not evidence of a real buyer or payment.

Cast note: Mara's wish is sincere. Do not play her as foolish for wanting safety, love or rest. June's precision protects those wishes from exploitation. Ivo's financial pressure is also real. The Presenter is frightening because the offer blends a real need with an impossible guarantee.

Director note: Show the sale montage as labour: a queue, ticket count, delivery obligation. Keep the "PERFECT" slide alluring for one beat, then let imperfect human sounds reclaim the room. Avoid graphic death imagery. The ending values the people present, without claiming they will always be together.

Producer note: No real \$10,000 sale is implied. Use original graphics, a fictitious payment interface and extras with consent. Do not film a real payment terminal, personal payment details or a false live revenue dashboard. The financial arithmetic is story logic, not an income method offered to viewers.